

the 1990s, the number of people in the UK who are aged 65 and over has increased by 1.5 million (1990–2000) and is projected to increase by a further 1.5 million by 2020 (Office of National Statistics 2001). The number of people aged 65 and over in the UK is projected to increase from 10.5 million in 1990 to 12.5 million in 2020.

There is a growing awareness of the need to develop strategies to meet the needs of the ageing population. The Department of Health (2000) has identified the need to develop a 'new paradigm' for the care of the ageing population. This paradigm is based on the principle of 'active ageing', which is the process of optimising the health and well-being of older people. The Department of Health (2000) has identified three key areas of focus for the new paradigm: (1) the promotion of healthy ageing, (2) the prevention of illness and disability, and (3) the provision of care and support for older people.

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